

connection, the device allowed a viewer to schedule recordings (even for TV shows over a period of months) and play and pause live TV.

This was the first device that really allowed the viewer complete control over his entertainment and that was the secret to its success. Now that we have Tata Sky HD+ and other such DVR services, we've taken it for granted. But when TiVo launched, it was a really big deal.

Television in the modern age

DVR is a very accurate reflection of the modern age. We want that level of control over what we watch, nay, we want more control. We want to watch what we want, when we want it and how we want it—unfettered by restrictive scheduling, the

line at the RTA. Why would you want to be tied down to a couch and a time slot?

It's not just that though, the TV is not interactive. In the year 2014, watching television is still one of the most passive activities that we indulge in. You basically channel surf or settle on something that you want to watch and then just sit and stare at the screen till you're done. There're no hilarious comments to read, you can't pause a moment and make a gif out of it, you can't even share a screen-shot—and this is probably why we spend more time fiddling with our phones than watching TV in the first place.

The TV doesn't learn your tastes and it's definitely not personalised. Even if all you really want to watch is sports and movies, you still end up paying for 500

incentive to actually develop a fully functional box that is in-line with modern expectations of performance and functionality.

UI and control

Designing a fluid UI and coupling it with powerful hardware costs money and it seems that most operators don't really care about investing that much when they're expect the content to speak for itself. The same goes for the remote, which, since the birth of TV has remained almost unchanged over half a century simply because the way we actually watch TV hasn't fundamentally changed in half a century – it was built for channel surfing in the '50s and is still used for channel surfing in 2014.

The likes of Samsung and LG are still experimenting with the so called "10 foot UI" and are yet to make some sort of real headway. We've seen radical UI designs and many attempts at replacing the remote control as a means of control, but nobody's yet been able to come up with a viable alternative to the ₹100 hunk of plastic that's as much a part of your living room as a couch.

Voice control is novel, but screaming at a TV that doesn't understand your accent isn't the right way of going about it. Gestures are also interesting (Kinect, PS Eye, etc.), but it's still hard for modern systems to differentiate conversational gestures from actual gestures directed at the TV.

You can use your smartphone to control your TV as well and it is more functional and efficient than a normal remote. This has its down-sides too as you can't be expected to control your TV while you're playing a game or answering a call. You'd need to hand over your phone to anyone wanting to control your TV and you definitely don't want the neighbour's pesky two year old brat handling your precious phone now do you?

As it stands, the traditional remote control is archaic, but still functional and it's because the TV is also exactly that – archaic, yet functional.

Why can't we stop watching TV?

Cable is dirt cheap

The whole problem with bypassing cable networks is that you can't bypass cable networks, at least not cheaply. Content creators such as HBO and ESPN earn the



Could a DTH or cable operator do justice to this setup?

censoring of censor boards and without the interruptions (ads) that mar an otherwise immersive program. We don't want to time our bathroom breaks to commercials, we don't want to stay up late just to watch Game of Thrones, we don't want to be stuck in an airport wondering what happened in Breaking Bad and hoping that we can wake up early enough to watch the rerun. Nobody has time for this much uncertainty and compromise anymore.

To put it even more simply, we want our entertainment on demand and our current TV infrastructure doesn't allow it. We want to watch our favourite show while we're emptying our bowels, while on a lunch break at work, surreptitiously during a boring meeting or at the waiting

other channels that you probably don't even care about. You don't get proper HD (other than a select few channels) and woe betide you if you're expecting to find 5.1 audio or something as new as 4K support.

The Set Top Box

Another huge nail in the TV's coffin is the Set Top Box (STB) that is currently our gateway to the "joys" of live TV. These boxes are a pain to setup, require a technician to install (most of the time) and offer interfaces that are far from responsive and clunky to boot. Using an STB is definitely not a pleasurable experience, but we don't have an option at the moment.

Consider the fact that STBs are subsidized anyway, giving cable operators less